



UNIVERSITY OF THE PHILIPPINES

Master of Science in Materials Science and Engineering

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Investigation of a-Si/SiO₂ distributed Bragg reflectors with InGaAs terahertz emitters

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

Recently, there has been an interest in developing terahertz (THz) photoconductive antenna (PCA) that can be activated by lasers operating at telecommunication wavelengths of $1.55\text{ }\mu\text{m}$ due to the possibility of integration with existing technology[1]. These PCAs are used in THz time domain spectroscopy (TDS) for various applications, including biology[2], imaging[3], and pharmaceuticals[4], among others. A PCA consists of a semiconductor material where the terahertz generation or absorption occurs and two metal electrodes on the semiconductor surface separated by a few microns that forms the photoconductive gap[5]. When a femtosecond pulse from the laser illuminates the gap, carriers are generated in the semiconductor and swept by an electric field from the bias applied to the metal electrodes, and the movement of the carriers generates the terahertz wave.

One of the common semiconductor materials of choice for a PCA operating at the $1.55\text{ }\mu\text{m}$ wavelength is low temperature (LT) grown indium gallium arsenide (InGaAs), which has a bandgap $E_g < 0.8\text{ eV}$ and can be grown lattice matched to an indium phosphide (InP) substrate via molecular beam epitaxy (MBE)[6]. However, InP is a strong absorber of THz radiation and can considerably weaken the THz signal produced by the PCA[7]. Additionally, there are losses involved during the illumination of the InGaAs thin film by the laser, as not all of the light is absorbed during the process[8]. Transferring the InGaAs thin film to a less THz absorbing substrate material with a distributed Bragg reflector (DBR) can increase the efficiency of the THz PCA by reflecting unabsorbed laser energy back into the film while also reducing the THz absorption caused by the substrate[9]. The difficulty lies in the transfer of the InGaAs film to the new substrate while avoiding damage.

1.1 Significance of the study

The development of THz PCAs compatible with telecommunication wavelengths holds great potential for integrating THz technology with existing optical systems. By enhancing the efficiency of THz generation, this study contributes to the advancement of THz TDS systems, which have diverse applications in fields such as biology, imaging, and pharmaceuticals. The current use of InP substrates for MBE growth of LT-InGaAs based PCAs allows creation of films operating at 1.55 μm wavelengths with acceptable strain. However, this setup faces limitations, including THz absorption by the InP substrate and inefficient laser energy absorption by the InGaAs thin film. By integrating a DBR stack, the study aims to address these problems, improving the THz intensity generated by the PCA and its overall performance. The findings could pave the way for more efficient THz devices, enhancing capabilities in scientific research, medical diagnostics, and industrial processes.

1.2 Objectives of the study

The main objective of this study is to enhance the intensity of THz waves generated by LT-InGaAs PCAs using a DBR stack made of amorphous silicon (a-Si)/SiO₂. Specifically, this will require the following objectives:

- to simulate an a-Si/SiO₂ DBR stack and fabricate it using magnetron sputtering,
- to integrate an InGaAs film grown via MBE for PCA with the fabricated DBR stack, and
- to evaluate the THz intensity of the integrated LT-InGaAs a-Si/SiO₂ DBR PCA device using THz TDS.

1.3 Scope and limitations of the study

The study will only cover the integration of an LT-InGaAs PCA with an a-Si and SiO₂ DBR. As such, the study will not investigate the growth of the LT-InGaAs film using

MBE and will also be limited to radio frequency (RF) magnetron sputtering as the growth method for the a-Si/SiO₂. The characterization is also limited to the evaluation of the THz intensity of the integrated device and will not include applications of the developed system.

CHAPTER 2

REVIEW OF RELATED LITERATURE

2.1 Terahertz photoconductive antenna

The range of frequencies between microwave and infrared in the electromagnetic spectrum is known as the THz range. It was also called the THz gap in the past due to the difficulty of finding emitters and detectors which worked in this frequency range[10]. THz radiation is non-ionizing and can penetrate through organic material such as plastic and clothing, thus it has potential use in biological characterization[2], detection of contraband materials[11], and chemical identification[12]. Some substances have specific THz absorption spectra which can be used to identify their composition, as shown in Figure 2.1. The interaction amongst the bonds and forces in the molecules result in vibrational modes visible in the THz region[11]. On the other hand, THz reflection can be used to detect concealed objects when the concealing material is transparent to THz radiation as in refthrough, as the case for dielectrics such as clothing[13]. A common setup for some of these applications involves THz TDS.

In THz TDS, a THz pulse is generated using a PCA. The shape of the electrodes influences the pattern of the THz radiation generated by the PCA. Dipole and bowtie

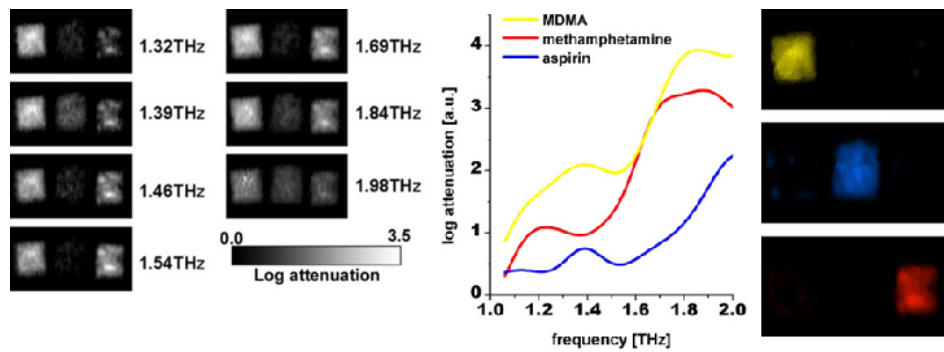


Figure 2.1: THz identification of MDMA, methamphetamine, and aspirin through a paper envelope. The substances are differentiated using their THz spectra[11]

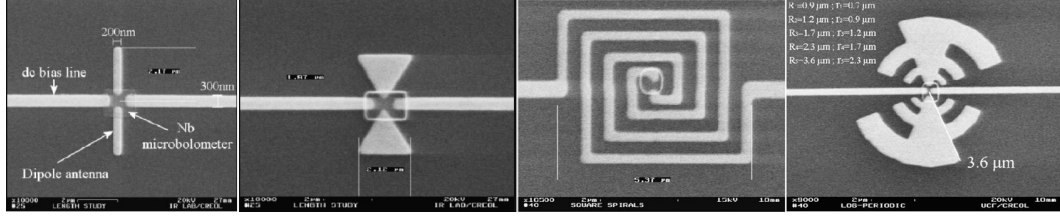


Figure 2.2: Commonly used THz PCA geometries; from left to right: dipole, bowtie, spiral, and log-spiral[14]

patterns demonstrate higher polarization ratios compared to spiral antennas while spiral and log-spiral antennas have a higher calculated radiation efficiency compared to bowtie and dipole antennas[14]. The shapes of the antennas are presented in Figure 2.2.

The emission mechanism for the PCA is as follows: the photoconductive material between the electrodes is illuminated with a femtosecond laser pulse, which generates photocarriers that are swept by an electric field applied to the electrodes of the PCA[5], [6]. The transient current $i_{PC}(t)$ resulting from the moving carriers generates electromagnetic radiation according to Maxwell's equations, with the intensity of the electric field component of the THz wave radiated by a dipole antenna expressed by Equation 2.1

$$E_{THz}(r, \theta, t) = \frac{l_e}{4\pi\epsilon c^2 r} \frac{\partial i_{PC}(t)}{\partial t} \sin(\theta) \quad (2.1)$$

where l_e is the antenna length, ϵ the permittivity, c the speed of light, r the distance from the dipole, and θ the angle relative to the dipole axis[5].

The transient current density term $i_{PC}(t)$ is proportional to the convolution integral of the carrier density $n(t)$ and electron velocity $v_e(t)$ as shown in Equation 2.2[5].

$$i_{PC}(t) \propto P_{pulse}(t) \otimes (n(t) v_e(t)). \quad (2.2)$$

The carrier density is described by

$$\frac{dn}{dt} = \eta \frac{P_{pulse}(t)}{h\nu} - \frac{n}{\tau_c} \quad (2.3)$$

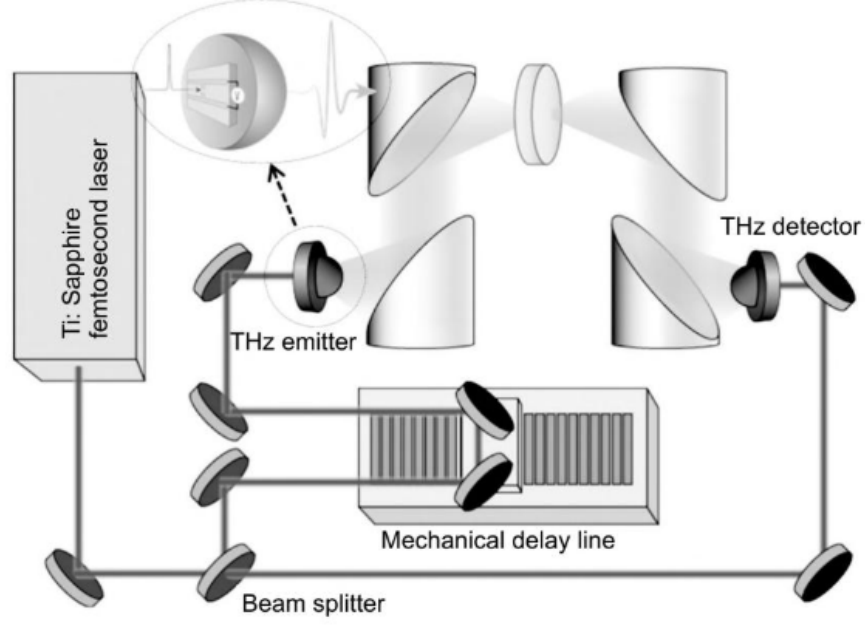


Figure 2.3: Schematic of a THz TDS setup with a femtosecond laser and two photoconductive antennas[5]

and using a 1D Drude-Lorentz model, the electron velocity by

$$\frac{dv_e}{dt} = -\frac{v_e}{\tau_s} + \frac{e}{m^*}E \quad (2.4)$$

where η is the absorption efficiency, $P_{\text{pulse}}(t)$ the ultrashort laser pulse power considered over time, τ_c , τ_s , and m^* the carrier lifetime, momentum relaxation time, electron effective mass respectively, and E the local electric field[5].

A photoconductive antenna is also used to detect THz radiation, with the incoming THz pulse focused together with a femtosecond pulse split from the same source at the gap of the antenna. As the femtosecond probe pulse arrives at the gap, carriers are excited and then accelerated proportionally by the electric field provided by the incoming THz pulse[6]. The difference of the probe pulse and the THz pulse provides a measurement in the time domain for the transient of the THz pulse. A schematic of a complete THz TDS system with emitter and detector is shown in Figure 2.3.

2.2 Low temperature grown InGaAs

From the previously discussed equations, the performance of the THz TDS system depends on multiple factors such as the properties of the femtosecond laser pulse and the quality of the photoconductive material. Modification of the photoconductive material is done to achieve short electron-hole recombination times, high carrier mobilities, and high breakdown electric fields, which all contribute to an increase in the intensity of generated THz radiation[15].

Some of the photoconductive materials used for THz TDS systems include LT grown GaAs and InGaAs[16], [17], [18]. LT-GaAs is grown via molecular beam epitaxy at 200 °C to 300 °C instead of the usual growth temperature around 600 °C[19]. The growth of GaAs and related compounds at relatively low temperatures and slower rates in molecular beam epitaxy compared to other epitaxial techniques result in mechanisms which are dominated by surface kinetics and surface chemistry[20]. MBE growth can be divided into two stages: the initial stage involving processes such as the chemisorption of molecules, their migration across the surface, and bond formation; and the subsequent stage which involves thermodynamic interaction and redistribution in the surface regions to form the crystal[20]. The molecular beam which supplies the material is produced by evaporation or sublimation of high-purity solid sources at elevated temperatures in ultra-high vacuum, allowing the molecules to reach the substrate without interacting. When the molecules arrive at the substrate, they are chemisorbed to the surface and can migrate to energetically favorable step edges or nucleated islands and form bonds, gather at contaminations to form defects or agglomerate with similar species, or desorb from the surface as shown in Figure 2.4[21], [22]. The thermodynamic interaction and redistribution of the layers close to the surface to form the final crystal configuration has been observed during the growth process of InGaAs using Auger electron and x-ray photoemission spectroscopy[23], [24].

The low growth temperature coupled with excess arsenic during the process creates a non-stoichiometric material with a high concentration of point defects in the form

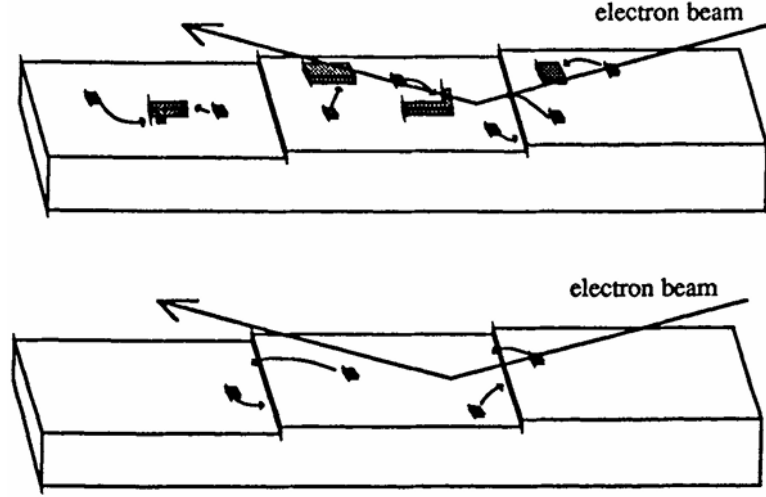


Figure 2.4: Kinetics of epitaxial growth observed using an electron beam. Molecules can form islands, migrate to step edges, or desorb from the surface.[20]

of As antisites As_{Ga} close to the center of the bandgap as shown in Figure 2.5 [25]. The As_{Ga} point defects can be found in the neutral As_{Ga}^0 and charged As_{Ga}^+ states, with reported concentrations of $1 \times 10^{20}/\text{cm}^3$ and $1 \times 10^{10}/\text{cm}^3$ respectively at a growth temperature of 200°C [26]. Close to the valence band, acceptor vacancies V_{Ga} form at equal concentration to As_{Ga}^+ . As_{Ga}^+ acts as an electron trap, and together with the other mid-bandgap states serve as a ready source of electrons that can be easily promoted to the conduction band, which results in a much larger carrier concentration in the conduction band compared to ordinary material which relies solely on band-to-band transitions[27]. Despite the high defect concentration of LT-GaAs, the material has been reported to have high carrier mobility of around $200 \text{ cm}^2/(\text{V s})$ [27].

The partial substitution of Ga atoms by In in the GaAs structure results in the ternary alloy $\text{In}_x\text{Ga}_{1-x}\text{As}$. Controlling the bandgap and consequently absorption wavelength for InGaAs is done by changing the mole fractions of In and Ga as shown in Figure 2.6 [28]. The ratios of In and Ga are easily controlled by changing the fluxes of the corresponding sources during epitaxial growth.

A phase diagram for the surface reconstruction of $\text{In}_x\text{Ga}_{(1-x)}\text{As}$ as a function of In composition on GaAs(100) and InAs(100) substrates is shown in Figure 2.7[29]. The gaps in the phase diagram indicate locations where the morphology of the surface is no longer uniform and flat enough to obtain data from scanning tunneling microscopy

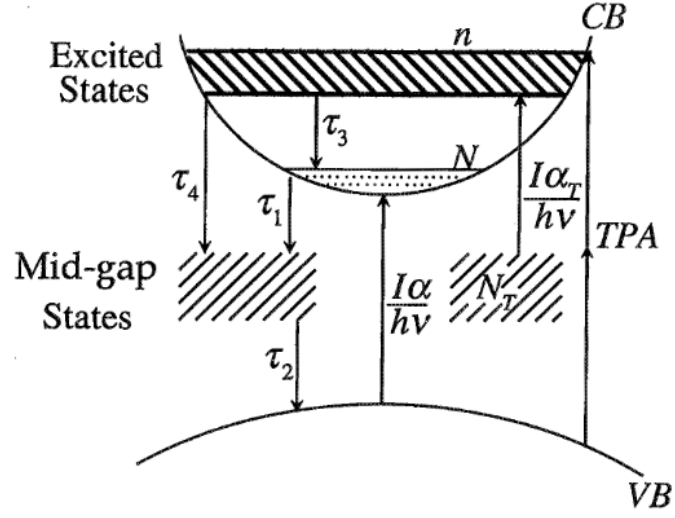


Figure 2.5: Energy level diagram of the defect states in LT-GaAs[27]

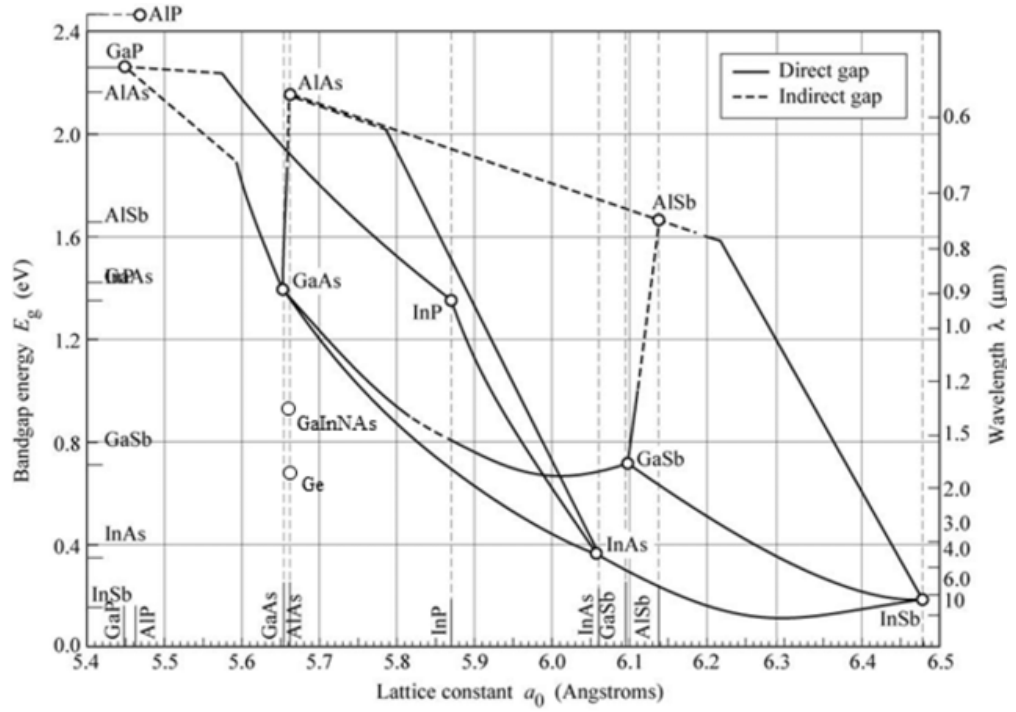


Figure 2.6: Bandgap versus lattice constant for various III-V compounds[28]

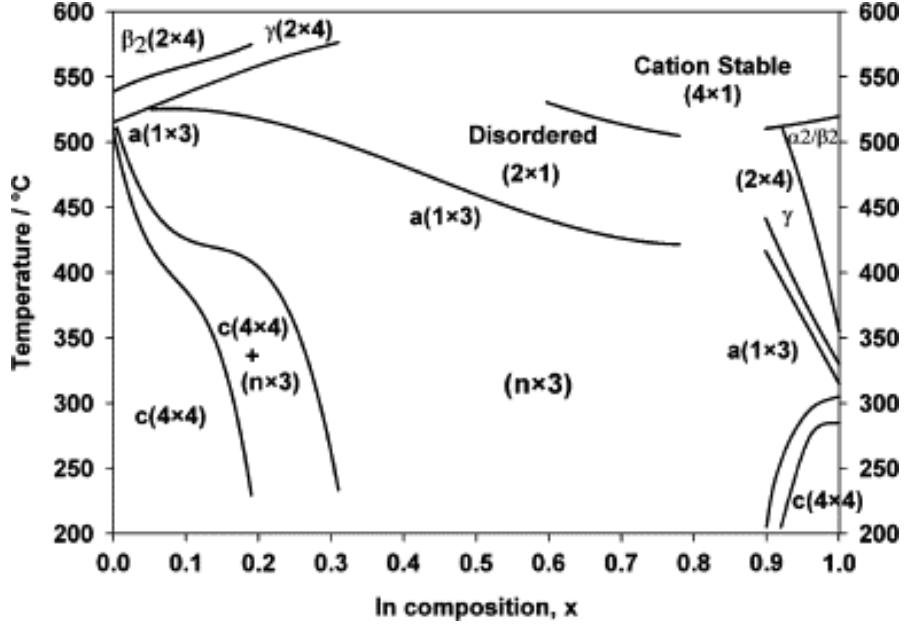


Figure 2.7: Phase diagram for the surface reconstruction of $\text{In}_x\text{Ga}_{(1-x)}\text{As}$ using RHEED (STM) and reflective high energy electron diffraction (RHEED).

For InGaAs on $\text{GaAs}(100)$ the system is compressively strained and becomes progressively rougher as the In fraction increases, while InGaAs grown on $\text{InAs}(100)$ is tensile strained, thus the choice of substrate is also important during epitaxy. Based on Figure 2.6 InP is the most suitable substrate lattice matched to InGaAs operating at $1.55\text{ }\mu\text{m}$, however InP is highly absorbing for THz radiation and has a relatively high refractive index which hinders efficient emission of THz radiation as shown in Figure 2.8[7].

2.3 Distributed Bragg Reflector

Increasing the absorption of the photoconductive material can be done by reflecting unabsorbed light from the laser back into the material by means of a distributed Bragg reflector[30]. A DBR is composed of a stack of alternating layers of materials having different refractive indices. When an electromagnetic wave propagates across the boundary of two materials with differing refractive indices, partial reflection of the field occurs if the refractive index of the succeeding material is greater than that of the material before it. If the thickness of each layer is set to a quarter of the wavelength of

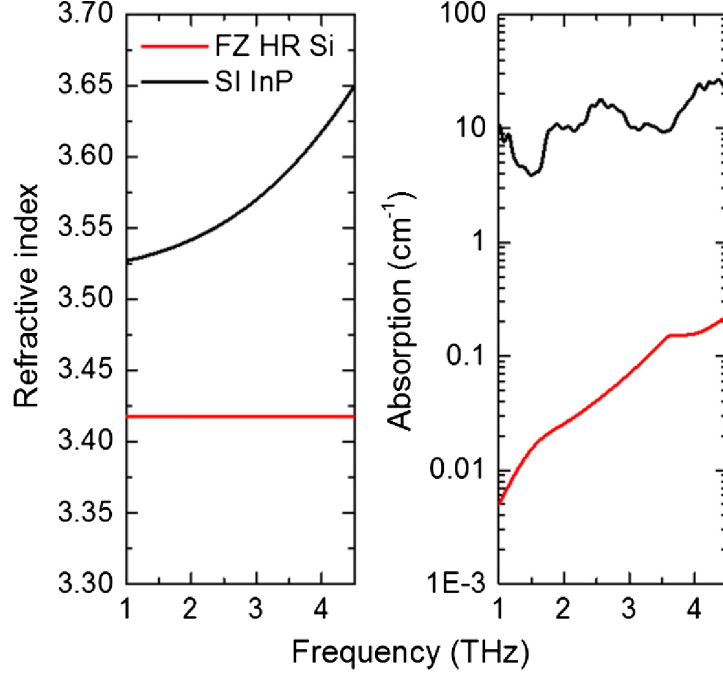


Figure 2.8: Refractive index and absorption coefficient of semi-insulating InP and float zone high resistivity Si in the THz range[5]

interest, the reflection from each successive interface is shifted by half the wavelength and the collection of all reflected components interfere constructively[31].

An explanation of the distributed Bragg reflector can be obtained from the wave equation as given by

$$\frac{d^2 E}{dz^2} + \left\{ \frac{\omega^2}{c^2} [n_0 + n_1 \cos(2\beta_m z)] + j \frac{\omega}{c} [-n_0 i \gamma_0 + \gamma_1 \cos(2\beta_m z + \theta)] \right\} E = 0 \quad (2.5)$$

where the involved terms are $\beta_0 = \frac{\omega}{c} n_0$ the phase constant of the unperturbed mode, $g_0 = \gamma_0/2$ the field coefficient, $g_1 = \gamma_1/2$ the perturbation in the field coefficient, $\kappa = \frac{\omega}{c} \cdot \frac{n_1}{2} + j \frac{g_1}{2}$ the coupling coefficient, and $2\beta_m = \frac{2\pi}{\Lambda}$ where Λ is the mechanical periodicity $\lambda_B/2n_0$. By using some approximations, Equation 2.5 can be reduced to the matrix equation

$$\begin{bmatrix} f'' \\ r'' \end{bmatrix} - p^2 \begin{bmatrix} f \\ r \end{bmatrix} = 0 \quad (2.6)$$

where $p^2 = \kappa^2 + (g_0 - j\delta)^2$. Returning to the example of the propagating electromagnetic wave E_+ at $z = -L/2$, if the medium through which it propagates is periodic

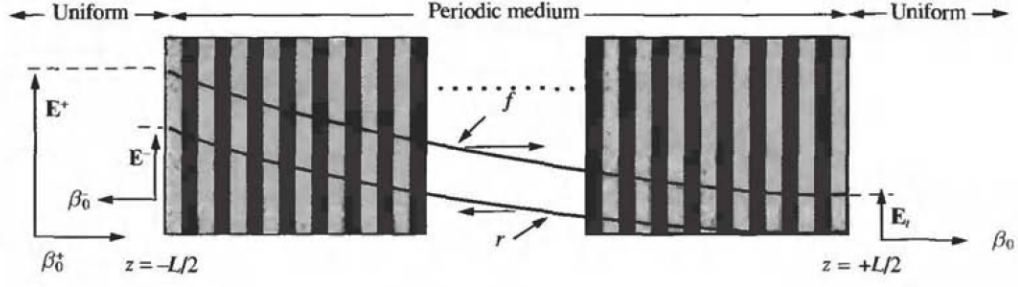


Figure 2.9: Geometry of a distributed Bragg reflector medium with a source of electromagnetic waves located on the left. The amplitude of E decreases as it propagates through the structure[32].

as shown in Figure 2.9, then a reverse wave r is generated which contributes to the reflected wave E_- at the same boundary. A portion of the propagating wave may reach the right boundary of the periodic structure at $z = L/2$ and turn into a transmitted wave E_t . There is no reverse wave at the right boundary since the medium beyond does not have the properties to reflect the wave. When the field gain coefficient $g_0 = 0$ (and also for g_1), the coupling coefficient κ is a real number, and Equation 2.6 simplifies to the equation

$$(pL)^2 = (\kappa L)^2 - (\delta L)^2. \quad (2.7)$$

The power transmission and reflection coefficients at the band center are given by

$$\begin{aligned} R &= |S_{11}|^2 \approx [1 - 2e^{-2\kappa L}]^2 \\ T &= |S_{12}|^2 \approx 4e^{-2\kappa L} \end{aligned} \quad (2.8)$$

The region at $-\kappa L < [\delta L = (\beta_0 - \beta_m)L] < \kappa L$ is known as the stop band of the DBR, since the wavelengths which satisfy this condition are heavily attenuated while propagating through the structure, as shown in the power transmission graph in Figure 2.10. The amplitudes of the propagating electric field decrease exponentially as shown in Figure 2.9. Some of the methods used to simulate the operation of DBRs include finite element analysis [33] and the transfer matrix method[34].

There are multiple material pairs that can be chosen for the DBR. A commonly used material pair is AlAs/GaAs, which can be grown via MBE[35]. Other material

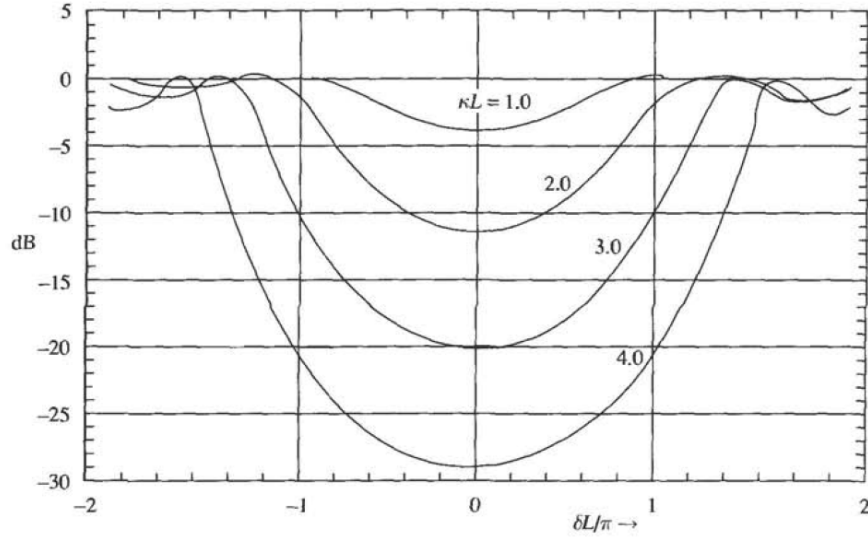


Figure 2.10: Relative power transmission of a DBR versus the detuning parameter $\delta L/\pi$ for various coupling coefficient κL values [5]

systems which have been grown epitaxially for vertical cavity surface emitting lasers based on InP substrates operating at $1.55\ \mu\text{m}$ include InGaAsP/InP, AlGaAsSb/AlAsSb, and AlInGaAs/AlInAs, but they require a high number of mirror periods to achieve saturation and the cost of such a growth process would be impractical[36]. A DBR made of Si/SiO₂ is more economical to fabricate, with processes ranging from sputtering to electron beam deposition, but the challenge would now be the transfer of the film from its original growth substrate to the fabricated stack. A transfer process that would preserve the integrity of the film becomes necessary. HCl is known as a selective etchant for InP while leaving InGaAs intact and has been used to isolate InGaAs from sacrificial InP layers with the resulting thin films maintaining an acceptable level of surface roughness and quality[37].

RF magnetron sputtering has been used to deposit a-Si and SiO₂ layers for different applications such as nanolaminate structures[38], superlattices[39], and DBRs for VCSELs[40]. Sputtering utilizes collisions between energized particles of the working gas and the atoms on the cathode target to supply the material to be deposited. Sputtering is done at vacuum pressures to reduce unwanted collisions between gas particles [41]. The working gas is commonly argon due to its inertness and availability.

In DC diode sputtering a discharge voltage V_D is applied to ionize the working gas,

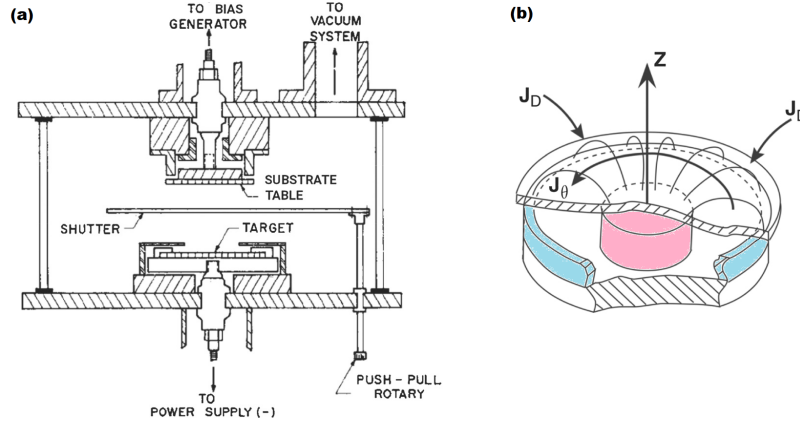


Figure 2.11: Schematics of a magnetron sputtering system (a) with cathode target (b). The plasma is confined by the magnetic field in a toroidal pattern[5].

as shown in Figure 2.11a. The applied V_D must be greater than the breakdown voltage V_B of the gas, in order to ionize the electrons from the gas particles and create plasma via an avalanche effect. DC diode sputtering works well when the target is conductive and metallic, but when the target is insulating due to its inherent properties or impurities then an interfering charge begins to build up. This build-up is avoided by the use of an AC voltage cycled at extremely high or RF. DC sputtering is also limited by the lifespan of the electrons in the vicinity of the target. Adding a static magnetic field $\mathbf{B}$ to confine the ions as shown in Figure 2.11b solves this problem, as it is easier to accelerate a charged ion q with velocity $\mathbf{v}$ according to the Lorentz equation:

$$\mathbf{F} = q(\mathbf{E} + \mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{B}) \quad (2.9)$$

where $\mathbf{E}$ is the electric field and $\mathbf{F}$ is the force experienced by the particle. Compound films can be formed when a reactive gas such as O_2 is included with the working gas, as a chemical reaction between the reactive gas and sputtered atoms can occur mostly at the surface of the substrate. The whole process is thus called reactive radio frequency magnetron sputtering.

CHAPTER 3

METHODOLOGY

3.1 Growth of a-Si/SiO₂ DBR via reactive RF magnetron sputtering

Simulations of the DBR stack will be performed using finite element analysis to obtain the thicknesses of the a-Si and SiO₂ films to be deposited. A Si wafer will be prepared for reactive RF magnetron sputtering by a standard RCA clean. The wafer will be mounted onto the substrate holder and then loaded into the sputtering chamber. A layer of SiO₂ will be deposited on the Si wafer by sputtering an SiO₂ target with O₂ as reactive gas, followed by a amorphous Si layer sputtered with a Si target. This process is repeated until two pairs of layers are deposited on the wafer. The thicknesses of the layers will be measured using scanning electron microscopy.

3.2 Transfer of InGaAs photoconductive layer to a-Si/SiO₂ DBR

The InGaAs thin film grown via MBE on the InP substrate will be transferred to the a-Si/SiO₂ DBR grown via reactive RF magnetron sputtering. The InGaAs film on InP will be coated with a thin layer of Apiezon wax for protection before the lapping of the InP substrate. After a sufficient thickness of InP is removed by lapping, the remaining InP substrate will be etched chemically by a HCl H₂O₂ solution, then the InGaAs film with Apiezon wax will be transferred to the a-Si/SiO₂ DBR by van der Waals bonding. A bowtie PCA pattern will be transferred to the sample via photolithography and metalized with AuGe/Ni/Au using resistive evaporation and electron beam deposition. The sample will undergo liftoff to remove excess metal and rapid thermal annealing.

3.3 THz TDS of InGaAs on a-Si/SiO₂ DBR

The THz emission characteristics of the InGaAs on a-Si/SiO₂ DBR PCA will be measured with a standard THz-TDS spectroscopy system. The beam from a 1.55 μm femtosecond laser will be split into pump and probe beams using a beam splitter, with the pump beam exciting the InGaAs on a-Si/SiO₂ DBR PCA and the probe beam optically gating a THz detector. The time domain and representative frequency domain spectra of the InGaAs on a-Si/SiO₂ DBR PCA will be analyzed.

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Gantt chart

[illegible]

ITEM	DESCRIPTION	UNIT COST	QUANTITY	TOTAL
Fabrication supplies				
Acetone	4L (JTBaker)	2,300.00	1 bottle	2,300.00
38% Hydrochloric acid	2.5L (JTBaker)	3,955.00	1 bottle	3,955.00
Photoresist	250ml (ma-P 1225)	37,200.00	1 bottle	37,200.00
Developer	2.5L (mr-D 526/S)	24,100.00	1 bottle	24,100.00
Si wafers	Si(100), 2", undoped	11,342.50	2 pcs	22,685.00
Others				
Printing				5,000.00
Characterization	Scanning electron microscopy			10,000.00
Total				105,240.00